EU V: European Citizenship and Identity (AUW)

Political Science — Master Notes · by Jakob V. Stangel

Required reading: McCormick, J. (2021), *Understanding the European Union: A Concise Introduction*, ch. "The EU and its Citizens," pp. 88–109 · Szczerbiak, A. & Taggart, P. (2024), "Euroscepticism and anti-establishment parties in Europe," *Journal of European Integration* 46(8), pp. 1171–1191.

Theme of the lecture. After four lectures on the EU's history and machinery, this one turns to its **people**: has decades of integration actually produced a **European identity** — and does it matter? The lecture runs a chain — **formal citizenship → identity → public attitudes → political consequences** — stressing that *one does not automatically lead to the next*. Along the way it tackles the **democratic deficit**, how citizens are represented, *why* individuals come to support or oppose the EU (four mechanisms), and the rise of **Euroscepticism** and the **politicization** of European integration.

> ★ **The heart of the lecture:** the EU's future "depends on the support of its citizens, not just its elites" — so citizen **attitudes** are now a real constraint on integration. But the links are loose: holding an **EU passport** (formal citizenship) does not make you **feel** European (identity), which does not determine whether you **support** the EU (attitudes), which in turn shapes what leaders can do (consequences). Europe has moved from a **permissive consensus** (leave it to the elites) to a **constraining dissensus** (a politically contested project).
> **Red thread:** what kind of political community are EU citizens citizens of — and when do citizens' identities get *activated* to reshape integration?

Key concepts to apply: *EU citizenship (rights + the Art. 20 "additional, not replacement" limit) · the democratic deficit · the knowledge deficit · federation vs confederation (the Moravcsik–Franklin debate) · indirect / direct / engagement channels of representation · second-order elections · identity as constructed, contested, changeable · nested / cross-cutting / marble-cake identities · civic vs exclusionary construction of Europe · the two-way identity ↔ integration relationship · permissive consensus → constraining dissensus · the four attitude mechanisms (utility · identity · cues · benchmarking) · hard vs soft Euroscepticism · Euroscepticism vs anti-establishment politics (Szczerbiak & Taggart's five clusters; the "fungible issue") · politicization of identities.*

The core puzzle, and the citizenship → identity → attitudes → consequences chain

Core: you are a **national citizen** *and* a **European Union citizen** — but what does that actually mean, and does it tell us anything about whether you *feel* European or *support* the EU?

- **The puzzle:** the EU **is not a state**, so what kind of political community are EU citizens citizens *of*? EU citizenship exists **alongside** national citizenship and grants rights tied to membership of the Union.
- **The lecture's chain:** *formal citizenship → identity → public attitudes → political consequences.* **Main idea:** one layer does **not** automatically produce the next; there are multiple layers of interaction between

them.

- **Why this is political:** the future of integration "depends on the support of its citizens, not just its elites." **Public opinion actively constrains leaders** — so understanding citizen attitudes is essential to understanding the EU's future challenges.

Three theories, three ways of thinking about citizens

Core: the three integration theories from earlier lectures each frame the citizen differently — keep them as lenses throughout.

Lens	How it sees the citizen
Liberal intergovernmentalism	citizens → **domestic preferences** → national governments → **interstate bargaining**
Supranationalism / neofunctionalism	**spillover**: integration creates institutions, rules and actors that develop **their own dynamics**
Constructivism	**identity, norms and socialization shape interests** — and integration can **reshape identities**

What does EU citizenship actually give you? (more important, yet less than it seems)

Core: EU citizenship is a real bundle of rights, but by treaty it is an **add-on** to national citizenship, not a replacement — "both more important and yet less than it seems" (McCormick).

The rights it grants (deck):

- **Free movement and residence** across the Union.
- **Vote (and stand) in European Parliament elections.**
- **Vote in local/municipal elections where you reside** (but **not** national elections).
- **Consular protection** from any other member state when outside the EU and your own state has no representation.
- The right to **petition the EU institutions** (Parliament, the Ombudsman).

The limits:

- **Additional, not a replacement.** Maastricht created EU citizenship; the **Lisbon Treaty, Art. 20** states it "shall be additional to and not replace national citizenship." You remain a citizen of your **home state**.
- **Social and psychological barriers** to real free movement remain — language, customs, laws, road rules, banking, local products. "There is a limit to how much common EU laws will help" an Italian settling in Estonia.

Background: citizenship, and the "people's Europe"

- **What normally distinguishes a citizen from a non-citizen** (McCormick, via Joppke): the right to **vote and run for office**, jury service, eligibility for the **armed forces**, protection from forcible removal, consular protection abroad, right of **re-entry**, recognition by other states, and a **sense of belonging**. Many ordinary rights (equality before the law, property, free speech, minimum welfare) are enjoyed by **non-citizens too** — which is why EU citizenship is thinner than it sounds.
- It took leaders **30+ years** to attend to how ordinary Europeans related to integration. The **Adonnino Committee** (1984–85) proposed the symbols of a "**people's Europe**": the burgundy **European passport** (from 1986), the **flag** (12 gold stars on blue, borrowed from the **Council of Europe, 1955** — the number is *not* the number of members), **Europe Day** (9 May, the Schuman Declaration anniversary), and the **anthem** (the "Ode to Joy," Beethoven's Ninth).
- The **Single European Act** eased **free movement of people** (provided one had health insurance and enough income not to be a "burden"); a **1991 directive** introduced **mutual recognition of professional qualifications** (3+ years of training).

★ The democratic deficit

Core: the **democratic deficit** is "the gap between the actions taken by the EU institutions and the ability of ordinary Europeans to **directly influence** those actions" (McCormick).

- **The deck's framing:** the **Commission (unelected)** proposes legislation and governs areas of **exclusive supranational competence**; treaty changes have often been negotiated **among elites**. *But* the EU also combines **direct and indirect** democratic channels — so the charge is contested.
- **Evidence critics cite (McCormick):** few of the EU15 held referendums on joining; **Maastricht and Lisbon** were negotiated largely behind closed doors; the Commission faces little direct accountability; **Council and COREPER** mostly meet **in secret**; the **EP cannot raise revenue or initiate laws**; citizens have **no say over Court appointments**; and formal citizen rights are modest.

The key move: it depends whether you treat the EU as a federation or a confederation

Core: McCormick's central argument — "*everything depends on how the EU is understood.*"

- As a **federation**, its democratic credentials would be **weak**.
- As a **confederation**, representation is *expected* to be **indirect** (national governments answer to voters and represent them in the EU's chambers) — so its procedures are "almost everything we could expect." The irony: to satisfy critics, the EU would have to **become the federation they oppose**.
- **The scholarly debate: Franklin (1996)** — the lack of accountability is a "**crisis of legitimacy**." **Moravcsik (2002)** — EU institutions are hemmed in by checks (narrow mandates, fiscal limits, super-majorities, separation of powers), so EU policy-making is "**clean, transparent, effective and politically responsive**."
- **Useful data point:** trust in the **EU has consistently outstripped trust in national governments**; and **2018 was the first year ever** that a majority of Europeans felt their **voice counts** in the EU.

The knowledge deficit

Core: a second, "more fundamentally troublesome" deficit — most Europeans simply **don't understand how the EU works**, which makes opinion unstable and leaves a gap "into which Eurosceptics have walked."

- **Stats:** in **2004**, **55%** thought the EU was created just after WWI and **50%** did not know the EP was directly elected; by **2019**, **70%** knew the EP is elected, but **31% had never heard of the Council of the EU**.
- **Consequence:** referendums are often decided on **other** grounds — the **2005 French** vote (≈75% admitted knowing little about the treaty; many voted on Chirac) and **Brexit 2016** (false claims; votes driven by the government of the day, the economy and immigration).
- **Exam tip (deck):** distinguish "**I/many people dislike a decision**" from "**the decision-making process is insufficiently democratic**." Only the second is a genuine democratic-deficit claim.

How are EU citizens represented?

Core: three routes, running from arm's-length to hands-on.

Channel	How it works	Bodies / tools
Indirectly	through your **national government**	European Council · Council of the EU
Directly	through your **elected EU representatives**	European Parliament
Through engagement	participation and active citizenship	referendums · EU-level interest groups · the **European Ombudsman** · the **European Citizens' Initiative (ECI)**

- **European elections** (every 5 years since 1979, by **PR**) are the one directly democratic channel — but they are "**second-order" elections** (Reif & Schmitt 1980): fought on **national** issues, used to send messages to national governments, with **low turnout** (from 63% in 1979 down to ~43% in 2009/2014, recovering to ~51% in 2019).
- **Referendums** on EU questions have multiplied (**46 votes, 37 since 1992**; Ireland 8, Denmark 7). Two types: on **membership** and on **treaties**. Denmark was the **first to reject a treaty** (Maastricht, 1992, by 50.7%); France and the Netherlands **killed the Constitutional Treaty in 2005**. The **euro** was put to a vote only in **Denmark and Sweden — both said No** — so no euro government has dared ask.
- **Interest groups** (e.g. **BusinessEurope**, the **ETUC**) cluster in Brussels and **help offset the deficit** by giving citizens a channel that **bypasses national governments**.
- **European Ombudsman:** handles complaints of **maladministration** by EU bodies (except the Courts); the **Commission** draws most complaints.
- **European Citizens' Initiative (ECI):** a Lisbon innovation — **1 million citizens from at least 7 member states** can invite the Commission to propose legislation.

European identity: who are "we"?

Core: European identity is **not a fact to be measured** — it is a set of **contested ideas** about who "we" are, which values define Europe, who belongs, and where Europe ends.

- In **social constructivism**, identities are **constructed, contested and changeable** — not fixed or natural.

Multi-level identities: one identity does not replace another

Core: national and European identities **coexist**; there are three ideal-typical ways they fit together.

Type	Image	Meaning
Nested	Russian doll	smaller collective identities **sit inside** larger ones
Cross-cutting	overlapping circles	different identity markers **overlap** with no single hierarchy
Blended	marble cake	national and European identities **interact and change one another**

Civic vs exclusionary constructions of Europe

Core: "Europe" is something political actors **construct** — and they build it in opposite ways.

	Civic construction	Exclusionary construction
Basis	shared **civic values**	**essentialist** cultural markers
Content	freedom, democracy, equality, human rights, rule of law	Europe as a **bounded cultural community**
Stance	inclusive, values-based	threatened by **migration, enlargement, outside influence**
Example	the **Lisbon Treaty preamble** ("universal values… freedom, democracy, equality and the rule of law")	the **Front National (2007)** on Turkey ("an Asian country… does not have its place in Europe")

The two-way relationship: identity ↔ integration

Core: constructivism's key claim — causation runs **both ways**.

- **Identity shapes integration:** what actors consider **desirable or legitimate** depends on socially shared identities, values and norms.
- **Integration shapes identity:** membership, institutions, **socialization** and shared experiences change how actors understand themselves.

★ From permissive consensus to constraining dissensus

Core: the politics of integration has flipped — citizens used to be bystanders; now they are a brake.

	Permissive consensus	Constraining dissensus (Hooghe & Marks)
Citizens	"leave Europe to the elites"; largely **accepted or ignored** integration	Europe is **politically contested**
Effect on leaders	free hand	**public opinion increasingly constrains** what leaders can do

- **The turning point was Maastricht (1992):** the **Danish No**, the UK's forced **ERM exit**, and the French "**petit oui**" put integration on the public radar and began to erode the permissive consensus (McCormick).

★ Why does one citizen support the EU and another oppose it? Four mechanisms

Core: attitudes toward the EU are driven by four overlapping logics — **utility, identity, cues, benchmarking**. Learn to apply all four to a single voter.

Mechanism	The question	Core logic
Utility	"What's in it for me?"	weigh **costs vs benefits** of membership
Identity	"Who are we?"	belonging, values, perceived **cultural threat**
Cues	"What do people I trust tell me?"	**shortcuts** from parties and media
Benchmarking	"Compared with what?"	judge the EU **against an alternative**

Utility — "what's in it for me?"

- Citizens weigh **benefits** (trade, mobility, investment) against **costs** (adjustment, regulation, redistribution, perceived loss of control).
- **Individual level:** the "**winners**" **of integration** (higher education, income, skills) are more supportive — the **elite–mass gap**.
- **National level:** citizens in countries that **benefit** (through trade or redistribution) are more supportive.

Identity — "who are we?"

- A **strong attachment to the nation does not by itself** imply opposition to the EU.

- But where national identity is **exclusive** (hostile to other cultures), Europe is easily framed as a **threat to "us"** → more likely to oppose the EU.

Cues — "what do trusted actors tell me?"

- Most citizens **do not follow EU politics closely** (information asymmetry), so **parties and media provide shortcuts**. Voters of **pro-EU parties** are more likely to be pro-EU — the cues matter even when the issue is not intrinsically important to the voter.

Benchmarking — "compared with what?"

- **Democratic benchmark:** citizens in **high-quality national democracies** may be **less** supportive of the EU.
- **Contrast / scapegoat:** citizens **dissatisfied with their national government** may become **more** supportive, seeing the EU as an alternative.
- **Economic benchmark:** citizens in **less affluent** states judge the EU on **economic** performance; those in **more affluent** states judge it on **political/democratic** criteria.
- **Worked case (deck):** a young Danish voter *benefits economically* from EU mobility and thinks Denmark would struggle outside (**utility → support**), *but* identifies strongly as Danish (**identity → oppose**) and follows a Eurosceptic party (**cues → oppose**) — the mechanisms pull in **different directions**.

Euroscepticism: opposition to what?

Core: Euroscepticism is **not monolithic** — it runs from wanting reform to wanting out. Taggart & Szczerbiak's classic split:

	Hard Euroscepticism	Soft Euroscepticism
Object	opposition to EU integration **in principle**	opposition to the **current direction / pace / extent**
Endpoint	can mean leaving — opposition to **membership itself**	membership **still accepted** in principle
Framing	**system** opposition	**policy** opposition

- McCormick: the term was coined in **mid-1980s Britain**; arguments vary by issue, time and country and are often "**less about hostility to integration than about immigration**." Eurosceptic parties made large gains in the **2019 EP elections**. Yet the **Spring 2019 Eurobarometer** found **59%** of Europeans wanted **more** decisions taken at EU level (only 32% opposed).

★ Is Euroscepticism the same as anti-establishment politics? (Szczerbiak & Taggart 2024)

Core: **No — there is no *necessary* link.** Classifying **77 parties in 30 countries** (expert-informed, 2018–19), the authors find Euroscepticism is a "**fungible issue**" that domestic politics frames differently; **anti-establishment** must be treated as a party feature **in its own right**.

- **Anti-establishment ≠ anti-system ≠ populism.** Anti-**system** (Sartori) rejects democracy itself; **anti-establishment** accepts the system but attacks the **entrenched elite**. It varies on two dimensions: **scope** (political / economic / cultural; left or right) and **action** (revolutionary → reformist → merely disruptive).
- **The five clusters:**

Cluster	Relationship	Examples
1. Anti-establishment, NOT Eurosceptic	see the EU as **part of the solution** to bad national elites; mostly **CEE** ("return to Europe")	En Marche (FR) · Save Romania Union
2. Eurosceptic, NOT anti-establishment	object to the EU **project**, not "the elite"; often **governing** parties	UK Conservative Party
3. Strong association (largest)	domestic + EU elites seen as **entwined** — possible **"EU-isation"**	National Rally · AfD · Five Star · The League · Fidesz · Syriza · Swiss People's Party
4. Both, but little interaction	the two run on **separate tracks**; mostly **CEE**	Law and Justice (PL) · Austrian Freedom Party · Vox
5. Anti-establishment, Euroscepticism not salient	the EU is a **"touchstone of dissent"** (Taggart 1998) — a "**box to be ticked**," not the appeal	Sweden Democrats · Sinn Féin · Podemos

- **Central thesis:** "Euroscepticism is a very **fungible issue**, and the structures of **domestic politics** play a crucial role in framing the national reception of European integration."
- **Take-home exercise (deck):** for the **Danish People's Party, Fidesz, Five Star, En Marche / Renaissance**, ask what each really opposes — EU integration? a specific policy? EU institutions/elites? **domestic** elites? national identity/cultural change? (often several at once).

★ Politicization: crises activate identities

Core: a crisis does **not automatically** lower EU support. **Politicization** is the process by which **political elites (parties, movements) activate/mobilize identities**, which then feed back into political processes. It turns on three questions: **solidarity** (who should help whom?), **responsibility** (who should fix it?), and **borders & belonging** (who belongs, and who decides?).

	Eurozone crisis	Schengen / migration crisis
Type	economic	cultural and political
Driving question	*how much solidarity?*	*who belongs in Europe?*
Focus	disputes over **responsibility** and financial support	**borders and belonging**
Outcome	Europeans **largely favoured European solutions**; **limited** "us vs them" framing	**Open Europe vs "Fortress Europe"**; **stronger mobilization of national identity**

★ Synthesis — citizens shape integration, integration reshapes politics

Core: the chain runs **both ways**, and **identity is the hinge**.

- **Citizens can shape integration:** domestic preferences, political constraints, electoral incentives and pressure on national governments (the **LI** lens).
- **Integration can reshape politics:** new institutions, rights, **socialization** and new political conflicts (the **supranationalism** lens).
- **Identity links the two:** identities shape interests, while political processes reshape identities (the **constructivism** lens). This is why the opening chain — *formal citizenship → identity → attitudes → consequences* — never runs in only one direction.

Cases & examples

- **The young Danish voter** — the four mechanisms (utility/identity/cues/benchmarking) pull in different directions (deck).
- **French 2005 referendum** — rejected the Constitutional Treaty; ~75% admitted knowing little, many voted on Chirac (knowledge deficit).
- **Brexit 2016** — the first whole country to vote to leave; driven by views of the government, the economy and immigration more than the EU itself.
- **Greenland (1982)** — the first territory to leave the Community.
- **The symbols of a "people's Europe"** — passport, flag (12 stars), Europe Day, "Ode to Joy" (Adonnino).
- **Lisbon preamble vs Front National (2007) on Turkey** — civic vs exclusionary constructions of Europe.
- **Eurozone vs Schengen crises** — solidarity framing vs borders-and-belonging framing.
- **Party cases (Szczerbiak & Taggart)** — En Marche (anti-establishment, pro-EU); UK Conservatives (Eurosceptic, not anti-establishment); Five Star / National Rally / Fidesz (both, entwined).

Key terms

Term	Meaning
EU citizenship	Rights tied to Union membership, **additional to** (not replacing) national citizenship (Lisbon Art. 20)
Democratic deficit	Gap between EU actions and citizens' ability to **directly influence** them
Knowledge deficit	Most citizens don't understand how the EU works, making opinion unstable
Federation vs confederation	The yardstick for judging the deficit (Moravcsik: as a confederation, the EU is responsive enough)
Second-order elections	EP elections fought on **national** issues, low turnout (Reif & Schmitt)
European Citizens' Initiative	1 million citizens from 7+ states can invite a Commission proposal
Constructed / contested / changeable	How constructivism treats identity
Nested / cross-cutting / blended	The three ideal types of multi-level identity
Civic vs exclusionary Europe	Values-based vs culturally-bounded constructions of "Europe"
Permissive consensus	Citizens leave integration to elites
Constraining dissensus	Public opinion now limits what leaders can do (Hooghe & Marks)
Utility / Identity / Cues / Benchmarking	The four mechanisms behind EU support or opposition
Hard / Soft Euroscepticism	Opposition in principle (→ exit) vs opposition to the current direction
Anti-establishment	Opposition to an entrenched elite; varies by **scope** and **action**; ≠ anti-system, ≠ populism
Touchstone of dissent	The EU as a marker of a party's oppositional **identity**, not its appeal (Taggart)
Fungible issue	Euroscepticism as malleable, framed differently across domestic contexts
Politicization	Elites **activating identities** around solidarity, responsibility, borders & belonging

Exam pointers

- **Run the chain** *formal citizenship → identity → attitudes → consequences*, and stress that **each link is loose** (an EU passport does not make you feel or vote European).
- **Apply the four mechanisms** (utility · identity · cues · benchmarking) to a concrete voter and show them **pulling in different directions** (the Danish-voter case).
- **Democratic deficit:** give **one argument for and one against**, hinging on **federation vs confederation** (Franklin vs Moravcsik); and distinguish "I dislike a decision" from "the process is undemocratic."

- **Hard vs soft Euroscepticism** with examples, and the key twist: **Euroscepticism ≠ anti-establishment** — cite Szczerbiak & Taggart's **five clusters** and the "**fungible issue**" thesis.
- **Civic vs exclusionary** identity (Lisbon preamble vs Front National) and the **three multi-level** types.
- **Politicization:** contrast the **eurozone** (solidarity) and **Schengen** (borders & belonging) crises, and note a crisis does **not** automatically cut EU support.
- Keep the **three lenses** (LI · supranationalism · constructivism) ready to read citizens, identity and attitudes.

★ Fun facts & memorable details (EU V: Citizenship & Identity)

> Sticky bits from the citizenship-and-identity lecture.

- **The flag's 12 stars mean nothing numerical.** The ring of **12 gold stars** was adopted from the **Council of Europe (1955)**; it stands for completeness/unity, **not** the number of member states (a common exam trap).
- **Greenland left in 1982.** Its ~53,000 voters made it the **first territory to leave** the Community — decades before Brexit made Britain the first whole country.
- "**It is far to Oslo, but further to Brussels.**" A 1972 Norwegian slogan capturing how EU opposition can be an extension of opposition to one's own capital elite.
- **The euro has never won a referendum.** It was put to a public vote only in **Denmark and Sweden — both said No** — so none of the 19 euro governments dared ask their citizens.
- **2018 was a first.** For the first time ever, a **majority** of Europeans said their **voice counts** in the EU — and trust in the EU has long run **higher** than trust in national governments.
- **In 2004, 55% thought the EU was founded just after WWI.** A vivid illustration of the **knowledge deficit** — and why Eurosceptics found an open goal.
- "**Quintessentially anti-establishment.**" Szczerbiak & Taggart's label for Italy's **Five Star Movement**; France's National Rally coined "**l'UMPS**" for the mainstream parties it accused of colluding with Brussels, and **La France Insoumise** called for a "**Sixth Republic**" to sweep away an establishment "fused with the EU elite."
- **Ireland has voted on Europe eight times.** A constitutional duty to hold treaty referendums gives a country of ~4 million the power to stall treaties for the whole EU (as with Nice and Lisbon).